The questions, therefore, that need to be addressed before we move on to subsequent events are: should Tawang have been abandoned? Could Niranjan Prasad have handled things differently? The ifs and buts apart, after the disaster on the Nam Ka Chu and the easy Chinese victories at Khenzemane and Zimithang, the Tawang battle simply had to be fought. Tawang had the potential to be the Kohima of the post-independence Indian Army. Whatever the earlier debates about the suitability of Tawang as a defensive location, there was no question of those arguments coming into play on 23 October after the Chinese had launched their attack on Bum-la.

Palit, far removed from the fighting on the ground, was allowed by Thapar to get Nehru's tacit approval to pull back. Bogey Sen, on the other hand, apparently had no intention of actually landing at Tawang (as his own staff would later confirm) but was forced to do so as his helicopter had a problem. Having set off from Tezpur on 22 October to do an aerial reconnaissance of the Lumla area he was unwilling to leave the helipad despite the Chinese building up to attack Bum-la just twenty kilometres away. The fact of the matter is that all the key commanders on the ground—Dalvi, Prasad and Sen—had mentally prepared themselves to flee rather than to fight. The moment the first escapees from the Nam Ka Chu arrived at 7 Brigade HQ at Rongla, Dalvi, instead of shooting the men for retreating, started preparing to abandon his own headquarters. At Zimithang, besides Assam Rifles and Bravo Company of 4 Garhwal Rifles, Prasad had a company of 13 Dogra. Yet he chose to fall back without offering a fight. By the time the retreating party reached Tawang, the will to hold ground was lost.

OLD WINE, NEW BOTTLES

After Thapar and Mullik returned from Tezpur (Palit was to stay back and orient the commanders with Se-la), the chief issued a series of fresh orders from Army HQ the next morning. Lieutenant General Bijji Kaul was to be replaced by Lieutenant General Harbaksh Singh (from the Sikh Regiment) as IV Corps Commander. Having served as Bogey Sen's deputy in 161 Brigade, which had spearheaded the fight in the Kashmir Valley in 1947, Harbaksh Singh had an excellent rapport with the troops, especially 1 Sikh. Both the battalion and the general had played a pivotal role in reversing the potentially disastrous situation. Having commanded 5 Division earlier,